

Advanced 4-Week B1 German Curriculum

A comprehensive, day-by-day roadmap leaving zero guesswork.

Week 1: Foundations of the Past & Daily Narratives

Day 1: The "Perfekt" Tense (Spoken Past)

- **Concept:** The absolute standard for spoken German. Unlike English, Germans do not use simple past when speaking.
- **Rule 1 (Sein Auxiliaries):** You **MUST** use "sein" only if the verb implies A-to-B movement (gehen -> bin gegangen, fahren -> bin gefahren) or state-change (werden, sterben).
- **Exception Alert:** The verb "bleiben" (to stay) uses "sein" (Ich bin geblieben) even though there is no movement. Memorize this now.
- **Action:** Write down 10 sentences describing what you did yesterday using "haben" (Ich habe gegessen) and 5 using "sein" (Ich bin gereist).

Day 2: The "Präteritum" Tense (Narrative Past)

- **Concept:** Used overwhelmingly in literature, news, and formal writing.
- **Rule:** Drop the "-en" and add "-te" (machen -> machte, sagen -> sagte).
- **Crucial Exception for Spoken German:** The verbs "haben" (hatte) and "sein" (war) are universally used in Präteritum even when speaking (say "Ich war müde" instead of "Ich bin müde gewesen").
- **Action:** Convert your 15 sentences from Day 1 into formal Präteritum.

Day 3: Modal Verbs in the Past

- **Concept:** Modal verbs (müssen, wollen, können) are almost always expressed in Präteritum structurally, even in casual conversation.
- **Conjugations:** musste (had to), wollte (wanted to), konnte (was able to), durfte (was allowed to).
- **Syntax Rule:** The modal verb sits at Position 2. The main infinitive verb is pushed exclusively to the very end of the sentence without "zu".
- **Action:** Write 5 complex sentences. Example: "Ich wollte gestern in den schönen Park gehen." (I wanted to go to the beautiful park yesterday).

Day 4: Vocabulary Deep Dive - Travel & Geography

- **Focus:** Navigating transit systems and explaining delays.
- **Key Lexicon:** die Verspätung (delay), der Anschluss (connection), umsteigen (to transfer), der Fahrplan (schedule).
- **Action:** Translate this exact scenario: "My train had a 20-minute delay, so I missed my connection and had to take a later bus."

Day 5: Vocabulary Deep Dive - Living & Housing

- **Focus:** Real estate and daily household chores.
- **Key Lexicon:** der Vermieter (landlord), die Miete (rent), der Mietvertrag (lease), staubsaugen (vacuuming), abwaschen (washing dishes).
- **Action:** Write an email to an imaginary landlord complaining that the heater (die Heizung) is broken and asking when they can fix it.

Day 6: Reading & Analysis

- **Concept:** Seeing the grammar in the wild trains the brain to recognize sentence flow.
- **Action:** Find a short German news article (e.g. on DW.com). Highlight every single past tense verb.
- **Analysis:** Identify why the author chose Präteritum versus Perfekt for each specific verb.

Day 7: Weekly Checkpoint (Writing)

- **Goal:** Synthesize Days 1-6 without looking at notes.
- **Action:** Write a continuous 150-word diary entry. Narrate a trip you took last year. You must correctly deploy: 2 Modal past verbs (wollte, musste), 3 Sein-Perfekt verbs, and housing vocabulary.

Week 2: Connecting Sentences & Expanding Descriptions

Day 8: Subordinate Clauses - The "Verb Kickers" (weil & dass)

- **Concept:** Conjunctions that force the conjugated verb to the absolute end of the clause.
- **Vocabulary:** weil (because), dass (that), da (since/because - used mostly in writing).
- **Syntax:** Hauptsatz + Komma + dass + ... + Verb. (Ich glaube, dass das Auto sehr schnell ist).
- **Action:** Write 10 reasons why you learn German starting with "Ich lerne Deutsch, weil..." ensuring the verb is perfectly kicked to the end.

Day 9: Subordinate Clauses - Time & Condition (wenn vs als)

- **Concept:** Distinguishing contextual triggers.
- **Rule 1 (Wenn):** Used for present, future, and repeated past events (Whenever I went to the store...).
- **Rule 2 (Als):** Used EXCLUSIVELY for one-time events in the past (When I was a child... -> Als ich ein Kind war...).
- **Action:** Write 3 sentences starting with "Als ich jung war..." and 3 describing a condition "Ich bin glücklich, wenn..."

Day 10: Adjective Declension - Nominative & Accusative

- **Concept:** Endings change based on the noun gender (der, die, das) and case.
- **Nominative Rule:** Describes subject. After "der/die/das" add "-e" (Der schnelle Wagen). After "ein/eine" add gender marker (Ein schneller Wagen).
- **Accusative Rule:** Describes direct object. ONLY masculine changes, catching an "-en" (Ich kaufe den schnellen Wagen / einen schnellen Wagen).
- **Action:** Create a grid combining (Masculine, Feminine, Neuter) with (Subject, Direct Object) and fill in describing a "red apple", "blue door", and "green book".

Day 11: Vocabulary Deep Dive - Work & Career

- **Focus:** Professional adult environments and job hunting.
- **Key Lexicon:** sich bewerben (to apply), die Stellenanzeige (advert), der Lebenslauf (resume), Feierabend machen (to finish work for the day).
- **Action:** Draft a highly formal 4-sentence cover letter requesting an interview.

Day 12: Vocabulary Deep Dive - Health & Body

- **Focus:** Surviving an urgent doctor's visit.
- **Key Lexicon:** die Schmerzen (pain), die Medikamente (medicine), das Rezept (prescription), sich verletzen (to injure oneself).
- **Action:** Write a paragraph outlining exactly what hurts (My head has hurt since yesterday and I have a fever).

Day 13: Listening & Pronunciation

- **Goal:** Train auditory recognition of subordinate clauses.
- **Action:** Listen to a German podcast (like Easy German). Pause immediately after you hear "dass" or "weil". Predict what the verb at the very end of the sentence will be before they say it.

Day 14: Weekly Checkpoint (Speaking)

- **Goal:** Fluidly execute verb kickers under pressure.
- **Action:** Open a voice recorder. Without a script, record a 2-minute mock phone call to your boss. Explain that you are sick (Health vocab), why you can't come in (verb kicker "weil"), and when you will return ("dass" clause). Do not stop the recording if you stutter.

Week 3: Advanced Nuance, Flow & Perspective

Day 15: Relative Clauses (Nominative)

- **Concept:** Modifying a noun without starting a new sentence. (The man, who is standing there...)
- **Rule:** Use the definite article (der, die, das) as a pronoun right after the comma. Like a subordinate clause, the verb is kicked to the end.
- **Example:** "Der Computer, der auf dem Tisch steht, ist neu."
- **Action:** Look around your room. Write 5 relative clauses describing objects you see.

Day 16: Relative Clauses (Accusative & Dative)

- **Concept:** The relative pronoun shifts depending on its grammatical role inside the clause itself.
- **Accusative Example:** "Das Auto, das ich gestern kaufte..." (I bought the car = direct object). Masc shifts to "den" (Der Mann, den ich sehe).
- **Dative Example:** "Die Frau, mit der ich spreche..." (speaking WITH requires dative, so "die" -> "der").
- **Action:** Translate: "The dog, which I am feeding" and "The friend, to whom I sent a letter".

Day 17: Dative Adjectives & Two-Way Prepositions

- **Concept:** The ultimate hack for Dative adjectives: Regardless of gender, if it follows a definite/indefinite article in Dative, the adjective ENDS IN -EN.
- **Example:** mit dem alten Mann, mit der schönen Frau, mit dem kleinen Kind.
- **Two-Way Preps:** in, an, auf, neben. Movement (Action) = Accusative. Static (Position) = Dative.
- **Action:** Write 5 sentences placing an object somewhere (Ich lege das Buch auf den Tisch) and 5 describing where it currently is (Das Buch liegt auf dem Tisch).

Day 18: Plusquamperfekt (The Past of the Past)

- **Concept:** Used exclusively to describe an event that happened completely before another past event.
- **Rule:** Simply take the Perfekt tense, and shift the auxiliary to Präteritum (haben -> hatte, sein -> war).
- **Example:** "Nachdem ich gegessen hatte, ging ich schlafen." (After I had eaten, I went to sleep).
- **Action:** Chain 4 chronological actions using "Nachdem" (After) and the Plusquamperfekt.

Day 19: Vocabulary Deep Dive - Media & Technology

- **Focus:** Navigating modern digital life.
- **Key Lexicon:** herunterladen (download), das Passwort, der Bildschirm (screen), der Datenschutz (privacy).
- **Action:** Describe the process of logging into an app, downloading a file, and experiencing a lag/crash.

Day 20: Vocabulary Deep Dive - The Environment

- **Focus:** Discussing critical modern societal issues.
- **Key Lexicon:** der Klimawandel (climate change), umweltfreundlich (eco-friendly), Müll trennen (sorting trash), die Energie.
- **Action:** Form a 5-sentence argument on why recycling is critical in modern cities.

Day 21: Weekly Checkpoint (Media Analysis)

- **Goal:** Prove mastery over complex chaining.
- **Action:** Watch a 2-minute German news broadcast. Write a summary of the sequence of events. You must use at least 2 Dative relative clauses and 1 Plusquamperfekt sentence to outline timelines.

Week 4: Professional Expression & Polish

Day 22: Das Passiv (Präsens)

- **Concept:** Used overwhelmingly when the action matters, and the WHO does it is entirely irrelevant.
- **Rule:** Use conjugated "werden" in position 2 + Partizip II at the end of the sentence.
- **Example:** "Das Auto wird repariert." (The car is being repaired by someone, we don't care who).
- **Action:** Walk through a factory in your mind. Write 5 passive present sentences (The boxes are being packed, the buttons are being pressed).

Day 23: Das Passiv (Präteritum)

- **Concept:** Giving historical facts where the perpetrators are irrelevant.
- **Rule:** Shift "werden" into the past -> "wurden". (E.g. ich wurde, er wurde, wir wurden).
- **Example:** "Dieses Haus wurde 1990 gebaut." (This house was built in 1990).
- **Action:** Write a paragraph describing the construction of an imaginary bridge in your city using Passiv Präteritum exclusively.

Day 24: Konjunktiv II Formations

- **Concept:** The tense of polite requests, wishes, and impossible realities.
- **Rule:** Auxiliary focus. hätte (would have), wäre (would be), würde (would do).
- **Example:** "Wenn ich reich wäre, würde ich ein Boot kaufen." (If I were rich, I would buy a boat).
- **Action:** Make 5 extreme hypothetical statements about what you would do if you were Chancellor of Germany.

Day 25: Vocabulary Deep Dive - Opinions & Debate

- **Focus:** How to structurally disagree without being rude.
- **Key Lexicon:** meiner Meinung nach (in my opinion), Da muss ich Ihnen widersprechen (I must disagree with you there), Einerseits... andererseits (on one hand... on the other).
- **Action:** Set up a theoretical argument about whether remote work is good. Argue both sides seamlessly.

Day 26: Conversational Formatting

- **Concept:** Buying your brain processing time during spoken debates.
- **Lexicon Fillers:** quasi (sort of), sozusagen (so to speak), naja (well).
- **Transition words:** allerdings (however), trotzdem (nevertheless), stattdessen (instead).
- **Action:** Re-record Day 14's phone call, but this time artificially inject "allerdings" and "naja" to sound massively more authentic.

Day 27: Describing Imagery

- **Concept:** Translating visual perception rigidly into structure.
- **Lexicon:** Im Vordergrund (in the foreground), Im Hintergrund (in the background), Oben rechts (top right).
- **Action:** Pull up any random stock image with people in it online. Speak out loud for exactly 3 minutes detailing everything you see precisely geographically.

Day 28: Final Checkpoint (Synthesis & Defense)

- **Goal:** Full conversational deployment.
- **Action:** Pick a controversial societal topic (e.g. Universal Basic Income). Speak aloud to an invisible partner. State your thesis, provide a subordinate cause, deploy a hypothetical Konjunktiv II defense, and conclude politely. You are now B1 ready.